

Lecture 2

Ethics and the Profession

Learning Objectives

After the completion of the chapter, the students will be able to:

- identify the ethical issues that influence professional decision making;
- analyze global computing issues that influence professional decision making;
- describe the mechanisms that typically exist for day-to-day ethical decision making;
- identify the progressive stages in whistle-blowing incident; and
- specify the strengths and weaknesses of relevant professional codes as expressions of professionalism and guides to decision making.



Profession

- a trade, a business, or an occupation of which one professes to have extensive knowledge acquired through long years of experience and formal education and the autonomy of and responsibility to make independent decisions in carrying out the duties of the profession



Profession

- a calling requiring specialized knowledge and often long and intensive academic preparation
- a principal calling, vocation, or employment
- the whole body of persons engaged in a calling”.

- Webster’s Dictionary



Profession

Four themes

1. evolution of professions
2. the making of an ethical professional
3. the professional decision-making process,
4. professionalism and ethical responsibilities



Evolutions of Professions

Origins of Professions

Profession

- a commitment formally *professed* by a person to become a member of a religious order, and a *professional* was the person who has professed the commitment.
- a commitment to “learned pursuits (divinity law, medicine and the military), being an authority on a body of knowledge, belonging to an occupation, being skilled or being a fractioned, not an amateur.”



Evolutions of Professions

Two Categories of Profession

First: **learned professions -** required individuals with a deep knowledge of the profession acquired through years of formal education

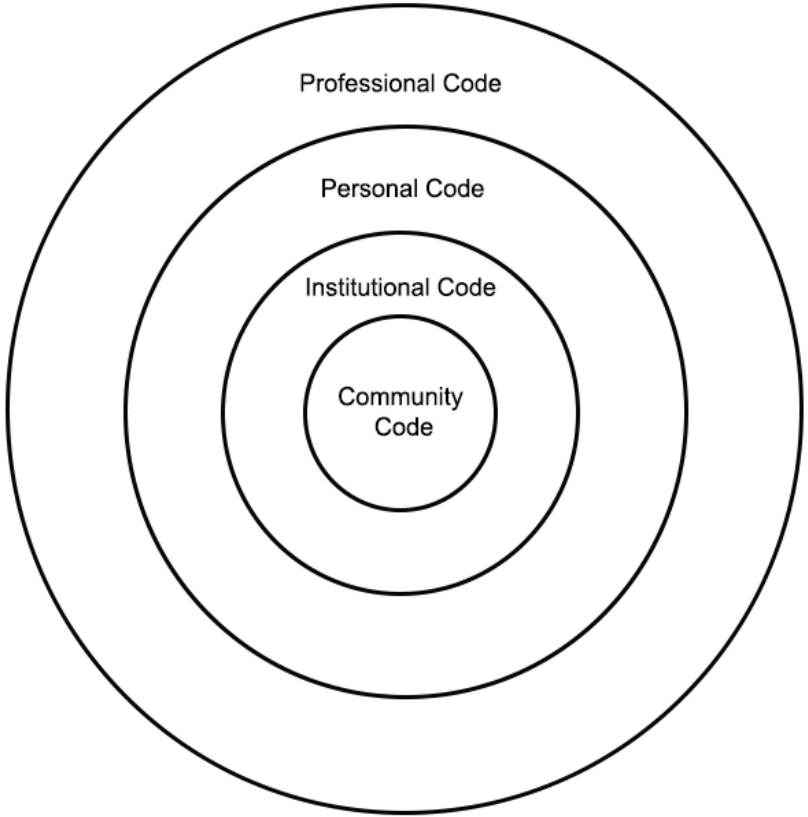
Second: **common professions -** which required the individuals to be noblemen who in theory did not really need to work for a living. (military career)



Requirements of a Professional

1. A set of highly developed skills and deep knowledge of the domain.
2. Autonomy
3. Observance of a code of conduct
   - professional code
   - personal code
   - institutional code
   - community code

Requirements of a Professional



Codes Governing Human Actions



Pillars of Professionalism

1. Commitment
2. Integrity
3. Responsibility
4. Accountability



Pillars of Professionalism

Characteristics of commitment

1. The person making the commitment must do so willingly without pressure.
2. The person responsible must try to meet the commitment, even if help is needed.
3. There must be agreement on what is to be done, by whom, and when.
4. The commitment must be openly and publicly stated.
5. The commitment must not be made easily.
6. Prior to the committed date, if it is clear, it cannot be met, advance notice must be given, and a new commitment negotiated.



Pillars of Professionalism

Maxims of Integrity

- ✓ Vision
- ✓ Love
- ✓ Commitment



Pillars of Professionalism

Types of Responsibility

- Personal
- Communal
- Parental
- Professional

- Responsibilities of a Professional as a Provider
- Service Responsibilities
- Product Responsibilities
- Consequential Responsibilities



Pillars of Professionalism

3 Key Elements of Accountability

1. A set of outcome measures that reliably and objectively evaluate performance.
2. A set of performance standards defined in terms of these outcome measures.
3. A set of incentives for meeting the standards and/or penalties for failing to meet them.

The Making of an Ethical Professional: Education and Licensing

Formal Education

1. Students take formal courses in professional ethics in a number of professional programs in their respective colleges.
2. Without taking formal courses in their curriculum, students are taught a good amount of the information ethics sprinkled throughout their courses, either in general education or in their major.
3. Using a capstone course in the general education requirements and in that course adds information ethics content. Many colleges now require computer literacy as a graduation requirement. Use that course to add ethics content.
4. Require an exit information ethics course which can be taken online.

The Making of an Ethical Professional: Education and Licensing

Licensing Authorities

Licensing - grants individuals formal or legal permission to practice their profession

The Making of an Ethical Professional: Education and Licensing

Professional Codes of Conduct

- purpose is to promote the public image of the profession by specifying and enforcing the ethical behavior expected from its members.

- Moral and legal standards
- Professional–client relationship
- Client advocacy
- Professional–public relationships
- Sanction mechanics
- Confidentiality

- Assessment
- Compliance
- Competence
- Certified professional credentials for those professions that use certification



The Making of an Ethical Professional: Education and Licensing

In order for professional codes of conduct to be effective, a profession must institute a system of *enforcement, reporting, hearing procedures, sanctions,* and *appeals.*

The Making of an Ethical Professional: Education and Licensing

Enforcement

- Drawing up the codes of ethics for the profession if none exist
- Revising codes if and when necessary
- Conducting education campaigns at the membership level
- Distributing copies of the codes to every member
- Developing disciplinary procedures
- Receiving complaints, conducting hearings, counseling members, and sanctioning members found guilty
- Promoting the image of the profession



Professional Decision Making and Ethics

Professional Dilemma in Decision Making

Advances in Technology

Incomplete or Misleading Information

Guilt and Making Ethical Decisions

The Making of an Ethical Professional: Education and Licensing

Reporting of Grievances

2 Main Reporting Procedures

1. Typical organizational route in which a complaint is reported first to the local chapters if it exists. The complaint then makes its way to the top, usually to the national ethics committee.
2. Short-circuit procedure in which reporting can be done at any level, and then from there a complaint is forwarded all the way to the top.



The Making of an Ethical Professional: Education and Licensing

Hearing Procedures

Sanctions

Appeals



Professional Decision Making and Ethics

Guilt and Making Ethical Decisions

- *Utilitarian criterion* —where decisions are made solely on the basis of their intended outcomes or consequences.
- *Rights criterion*—where decisions are made based on the set of liberties the society enforces such as the Magna Carta.
- *Justice criterion*—which reflect justice. Decisions are made so that they are fair, impartial, and equitable to all.



Professional Decision Making and Ethics

- Examining the ethically relevant issues, principles, standards, and practices
- Determining the different parties (and their special interests) who will be affected by the decision
- Deciding on an alternative course of action if and when the outcome of the decision is not what is expected
- Considering the probable consequences (short and long term) of each alternative on each of the different parties involved



Professional Decision Making and Ethics

- Thinking of consulting with a trusted colleague if the situation is complex, risky, or there is undue personal involvement
- Determining how personal values, biases, beliefs, or self-interests influenced the decision (either positively or negatively) and whether the consequences of the decision have been evaluated
- Being prepared to assume responsibility for the consequences of the action including correction of negative consequences.



Professional and Ethical Responsibilities

Whistle-blowing

- blowing gives the impression of an act of seeking public attention

Different Methods of Whistle Blowing

- Computer Aided Methods
- Traditional Methods
  - ❑ Fear of reprisals
  - ❑ Suspicion surrounding whistle blowing
  - ❑ Membership in organizational channels



Harassment and Discrimination

1. Awareness
2. Prevention



Ethical and Moral Implications

- The act of whistle-blowing is meant to alert and call the public to be witnesses to illegal acts that may be hazardous to their health and well-being or to waste of public resources.
- Even people with high moral standards can be prevented from doing what is morally right because of the privileges, rights, and freedoms they stand to lose within the organization if they become known.



Ethical and Moral Implications

- Harassment and discrimination are both evil acts that challenge not only the conscious of an individual doing the acts, but also, they create a situation that brings discomfort and inferiority to the targeted individual. It is, however, unfortunate that most individuals perpetuating the acts of discrimination and harassment lack the moral conviction and conscience.